got the projects going. The very first railway line in the subcontinent ran 21 miles (34 km) from Bombay to Thane. The formal inauguration was performed at Bori Bandar on 16 April 1854 when 14 carriages with 400 guests left the station ‘amidst the loud applause of a vast multitude and the salute of 21 guns’. A year later, a train left Howrah (a town across the river from Calcutta) and steamed up to Hooghly thereby establishing the first line in the east. Two years later, the first line in the south was established by the Madras Railway Company. By 1859, there was even a line between Allahabad and Kanpur.

An Indian railways map of March 1868 shows that by this time Howrah (i.e. Calcutta) had been connected to Delhi and the line was being extended to Lahore. The Lahore–Multan line had also been built, some of it with the use of four-thousand-year-old Harappan bricks. From Multan one could use the Indus Steam Flotilla to sail down to Karachi. In the west, Bombay had been connected to Ahmedabad and Nagpur but the link to the Delhi–Calcutta line was still not complete. Similarly, the link between Madras and Bombay was still being built near Sholapur. There were a number of side lines already in operation or being built.